

UNIT 5 / 3.1 Case Study: Ethical Analysis of Dave's Actions

Dave works as a programmer for a large software company. He writes and tests utility programs such as compilers. His company operates both day and night. At night, batch production jobs are completed. Dave learns that the night shift has extra programming capacity, so that extra work could be done during the night shift that would not adversely affect performance of the computers. Dave comes back after normal hours to develop a program to manage his own stock portfolio. He uses very few expendable supplies, such as printer paper.

Is Dave's behaviour ethical?

Dave is using company computers, company time (even if outside his shift) and company resources for his own personal project, managing his stock portfolio. Even though he uses few physical materials and believes there is spare capacity at night, this is still **unethical** because:

- The equipment does not belong to him.
- He did not receive permission to use it.
- Personal use of company resources can break policy and trust.

So **his behaviour is not ethical**, even if he thinks it does no harm.

Would the ethics change in these situations?

1. If Dave began a business managing stock portfolios for many people for profit

This becomes **even more unethical**.

He would be using company equipment to run a personal business, earning money from resources he does not own. This crosses into serious misuse because:

- He gains personal profit from company property.
- It could expose the company to legal or security risks.
- It shows deliberate exploitation, not an innocent side project.

So this scenario makes the situation **much worse**.

2. If Dave's salary was below average and he felt he "deserved" computer use as a benefit

This does **not** make the behaviour ethical. Feeling underpaid does not give an employee the right to take company resources for personal use. Ethical behaviour is not based on personal feelings of fairness. Only the employer can decide what benefits staff get.

So, even if Dave feels underpaid, his actions remain **unethical**.

3. If Dave's employer knew other workers did the same and did nothing about it

This might make Dave think the behaviour is acceptable, but **it still isn't ethical**.

Because:

- "Others do it" does not make it right.
- The company's failure to enforce rules does not remove ethical responsibility.
- Dave still needs permission before using resources.

However, the company would also share some responsibility for not setting clear rules.

So the behaviour remains **unethical**, but company culture makes the situation more complicated.

4. If Dave worked for a government office and reasoned that the computer belonged "to the people"

This is still **unethical**.

Government equipment is meant for government work, not for personal projects.

"Belonging to the people" does not mean employees can use it however they want.

Misuse of public resources can even break laws or policies.

So it is **still unethical**, and possibly even more serious because public money is involved.